RIA DUTTA

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development, Political Economy, Deep Learning

EDUCATION

Azim Premji University 2017 – 2019
MA in Public Policy and Governance *Bengaluru, India*
Thesis: Rethinking Reservation Policy for Scheduled Castes in India GPA: 8.51/10
Coursework: Causal and Inferential Methods, Understanding India with Data, Methods for Evaluation and Impact Assessment, Policy Analysis

Tata Institute of Social Sciences 2014 – 2017
BA Economics, History, Sociology Mumbai, India
Dissertation: Impact of the 2008 Financial Crisis on the Indian Economy GPA: 8.6/10
Coursework: Advanced Mathematics, Quantitative Research Methods, History, Microeconomics, Theories of Sociology and Anthropology

TECHNICAL STRENGTHS

Programming	Python, R, Stata, Julia
Software	Git, Bash, LaTeX
Packages	TensorFlow, PyTorch
Languages	English, Bengali, Hindi, Marathi

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Consultant for Prof. M.R Sharan (University of Maryland) Sept 2023 – May 2025
University of Maryland *Bihar, India*

- Implemented field-based Randomized Control Trial across 10 districts in Bihar, evaluating the causal impact of peer networks on local governance among 7,700 elected politicians
- Developed monitoring frameworks to assess public expenditure patterns and governance outcomes
- Managed 50-person field team, ensuring quality standards for in-person and phone surveys
- Designed, bench-tested and deployed surveys across 10 districts in SurveyCTO
- Liaised with government officials at the state and district levels to align research with policy priorities

Senior Research Associate for Michael Walton (Harvard) March 2022 – August 2023
IMAGO Global Grassroots *Madhya Pradesh, India*

- Led monitoring and evaluation of national anti-poverty programs resulting in asset creation and income effects across 5 districts in Madhya Pradesh using mixed-methods evaluation
- Web-scraped administrative data using Python and created structured panels dataset after merging with primary survey data
- Developed a measurement and evaluation system to assess the service delivery of the employment guarantee scheme (MGNREGS) and the National Rural Livelihood Mission (NRLM)
- Implemented Difference-in-Differences to estimate intervention impacts on 150 women's collectives

Research Associate for Prof. Seema Jayachandran (Princeton) March 2021 – February 2022
J-PAL South Asia *New Delhi, India*

- Led a field-based Randomized Control Trial to evaluate a school-based gender-equity program, impacting 38,000 students in 314 schools across 4 districts in Haryana
- Monitored data quality protocols using automated dashboards and Stata-based monitoring tools
- Supervised and trained a 150-member field team including surveyors, project assistants, and executives
- Developed the Pre-Analysis Plan and contributed to the manuscript for publication

Research Associate August 2019 – March 2021
IFMR LEAD *New Delhi, India*

- Built a credit scoring model using machine learning (t-SNE) for rural women entrepreneurs
- Monitored data quality protocols for 1,200 women entrepreneurs across 8 districts to evaluate market and credit access constraints
- Managed field teams of 35 and trained staff on data collection and project operations
- Led partnerships with the Ministry of Rural Development and industry stakeholders
- Co-authored policy briefs and research reports for government and donors

PUBLICATIONS

Invisible Entrepreneurs: Understanding the market landscape and enterprise readiness for women-led home-based businesses in Tamil Nadu and Rajasthan, *IWWAGE, 2020.* Link

Business Readiness Scorecard for Women, *IWWAGE, 2020.* Link

Women Entrepreneurs as the Powerhouse of Recovery, *LEAD, 2020 (pp. 1620).* Link

Youth Solutions Report, *United Nations Sustainable Development Solutions Network, 2020.* Link

Moving the Needle from Subsistence to Growth for Home-based Businesses, *IWWAGE, 2020.* Link

Invisible Entrepreneurs: How to Empower Women Behind Their Craft, *AVPN Blog, 2021.* Link